Storyteller

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Sam Evans
Reviewed by: Deb Orrock
Updated on 12 September 2025

‘Storyteller’

Here is a detailed guide to Liz Lochhead’s poem ‘Storyteller’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Lochhead’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Lochhead’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Liz Lochhead’s intention and message

‘Storyteller’ overview

The poem ‘Storyteller’, written by Liz Lochhead, describes a storyteller who is central to a community of peasant women. The poem celebrates the way listening to stories offers escape from the women’s work, and explores the social importance of stories and tales.

‘Storyteller’ breakdown

Lines 1–5

> **“she sat down**
> **at the scoured table**
> **in the swept kitchen**
> **beside the dresser with its cracked delft.**
> **And every last crumb of daylight was salted away.”**

simple kitchen:
    - There are some "cracked delft" (Dutch plates) on the "dresser"

- She has finished all her domestic chores:
    - The table has been scrubbed, the floor swept, and it is dark ("daylight" has been "salted away")

Lochhead's intentions

- Lochhead begins an immersive description of a woman at the end of a day of domestic chores:
    - Lochhead uses metaphor "crumbs of daylight" and "salted away" to convey the idea that the woman's life revolves around domestic activities

- The setting is a simple, yet well cleaned kitchen, introducing themes of domestic labour, as well as pride in one's environment

Lines 6–11

> **"No one could say the stories were useless**
> **for as the tongue clacked**
> **five or forty fingers stitched**
> **corn was grated from the husk**
> **patchwork was pieced**
> **or the darning done."**

Translation

- The speaker goes on to say that everyone agrees the stories have a purpose
- The woman tells long stories (her tongue "clacked"), while other women prepare food (grate "corn") or sew ("stitched" and "darning")

Lochhead's intentions

- The enjambment and alliteration in these lines, such as "patchwork was pieced", reflects long, passionate stories that help the women through dull work
- Lochhead highlights the power of storytelling, and the sense of community between the women despite their many chores:
    - The tasks are combined with listening to the tales, implying the stories are just as important as the work

Lines 12–14

> **"Never the one to slander her shiftless.**
> **Daily sloven or spotless no matter whether**
> **dishwater or tasty was her soup."**

while others worked, so she was "shiftless"
- They did not mind, though, so they would not "slander" or speak ill of her
- They liked the storyteller, whether untidy ("sloven"), and if the soup was "tasty" or like "dishwater"

Lochhead's intentions

- Lochhead emulates the excitement of the stories by portraying how all other matters were ignored, which shows a close community
- The strange and ambiguous combination of words may reflect the way the storyteller crafts her stories

Lines 15-18

> **"To tell the stories was her work.**
> **It was like spinning,**
> **gathering thin air to the singlest strongest**
> **thread. Night in"**

Translation

- The speaker says that telling stories was the woman's job
- When she tells stories it is as if she is spinning cotton ("thread")

Lochhead's intentions

- The present tense verbs "spinning" and "gathering" creates a sense of immediacy, which helps to convey the excitement of the storytelling
- The simile, "like spinning", connotes to the suspenseful stories the storyteller tells:
  - The metaphor 'spinning a yarn' is a nineteenth century sailors' expression
  - It is thought to describe the custom of telling stories during dull work such as yarn-twisting or thread weaving
- The metaphor "gathering air" may allude to the storyteller pausing for breath

Lines 19-20

> **"she'd have us waiting, held**
> **breath, for the ending we knew by heart."**

Translation

- The speaker adds that each night they would meet to hear the rest of the story, even though they often knew exactly how it would end

the storyteller builds anticipation that lasts all day, which is a welcome relief from the boring routine
- The power of stories is conveyed in the emotive "we knew by heart", alluding to how well loved they were, like fairytales

Lines 21-25

> **"And at first light**
> **as the women stirred themselves to build the fire**
> **as the peasant's feet felt for clogs**
> **as thin grey washed over flat fields**
> **the stories dissolved in the whorl of the ear"**

Translation

- The speaker explains that the stories were told at night and then, in the morning, the women finally moved to make a fire and find their shoes ("clogs")
- The speaker describes the "grey" sky and "flat fields" outside the home
- The night's stories run around in their heads ("in the whorl of the ear")

Lochhead's intentions

- Lochhead describes a cosy domestic scene with a "fire" and the alliterative "feet felt"
- This is contrasted with the landscape outdoors, which is "thin grey" and "flat"
- Despite the dullness and routine of their lives, the stories bring excitement

Lines 26-30

> **"but they**
> **hung themselves upside down**
> **in the sleeping heads of the children**
> **till they flew again**
> **in the storytellers night."**

Translation

- The speaker compares the stories with bats who sleep "upside down" during the day
- The stories are in the children's minds, and they will be spoken of again at nighttime

Lochhead's intentions

- Lochhead's poem ends with a metaphor that brings a sense of mystery to the stories:
    - The final line alludes to stories as bats flying at night, presenting stories as mysterious and exciting, but

tradition

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes. Specifically, examiners reward answers that consider the "deeper meanings of the poem". This means you should spend time thinking about, for example, the reason Liz Lochhead creates a simple setting in which to present the excitement of storytelling.

Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. All three are valuable "writer's methods" to explore when you answer the poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam. You should consider the poet's choice of form (its shape and the perspective of the speaker), its structure (the speaker's tone of voice), and the language used to create effect and meaning.

Examiners require you to focus on the poem's deeper ideas, and in a sensitive way. So, discuss how the poet's methods reveal their ideas or themes. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Liz Lochhead's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Liz Lochhead creates a long, immersive, free flowing form to portray the significance of stories to peasant women in a small community.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The poem's four stanzas increase in length as the poem progresses: this mimics the women's emotions as events of the evening unfold (before the stories, during the stories, and afterwards)	Lochhead's poem reflects the women's anticipation of the nightly stories, and the way storytelling brings the community together

Structure

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's lack of rhyme scheme, along with fluid lines, mimics the lengthy nature of the woman's storytelling, but anaphora in line 22–24 contrast the free-flowing rhythm to reflect the dullness of the women's daily lives	Lochhead illustrates how the women complete the same daily tasks in the same kitchen day after day, but she suggests that stories relieve this boredom and, thus, she raises the profile of traditional storytelling

Language

Liz Lochhead's poem creates a vivid image of how the dull lives and mundane chores of modest and marginalised women are enriched and motivated by stories told around a kitchen table.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	While the poem begins with the immersive "she sat down" and a description of a simple kitchen with "cracked" plates and a "scoured" table to portray a simple life, the stories told in the kitchen are presented as exciting with onomatopoeia, like in "clacked" and "husk", as well as rich metaphor alluding to spinning wheels and bats	Lochhead shows how stories become part of the rich tradition of a small peasant community of domestic women

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed, personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the poem's **themes, main ideas, settings, situations** and **events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Liz Lochhead examines in her poem 'Storyteller':

- Individual identity
- Cultural identity

engagement" is to engage with the key words of the question and think carefully about your introduction. Examiners suggest that you set up a clear argument that focuses on the writer's purposes or aims. Think about why the poet raises certain themes, or what ideas are challenged in their poem. This might be because of their background or the society they lived in. This is how you can connect 'context' to your argument.

Individual identity

- Liz Lochhead is a Scottish poet, born in 1947
- Her work is inspired by American feminist writers who rework old myths, as well as Scottish oral culture and European myths
- The poem 'Storyteller' is the introduction to a series of poems called The Grimm Sisters, written in 1981:
  - The collection reworks old fairy-tales and myths with a feminist perspective, particularly those written by the Brothers Grimm
- Lochhead's work re-enchants or subverts everyday reality with mythic and fairytale elements:
  - In her poem 'Storyteller', the lives of domestic women are enriched by magical stories that dissolve in the "into the whorl of the ear"
  - In 'Storyteller' Lochhead presents a female orator who is able to capture the attention of a community all night because of her masterful narratives
- Some of the references in the poem suggest the setting is Dutch:
  - For example, there are "flat fields", the women wear "clogs", and the plates are "cracked delft"
  - Arguably, the poem represents the daily chores of any domestic woman
  - They sit around a "scoured table" and a "swept" floor

Cultural identity

- Twentieth century literature saw a revival of the oral tradition of storytelling, and often celebrates the power of performance poetry:
  - Liz Lochhead's poetry uses alliteration and onomatopoeic words to elevate the sound of the language
  - For example, in the lines, "the tongue clacked/five or forty fingers" or in "darning was done" and "peasant's feet felt for clogs"
- Lochhead's poem 'Storyteller' raises the idea of cultural continuity through storytelling:
  - The celebrates the way a woman captivates her community with her suspenseful storytelling around a kitchen table
  - For instance, in the line, "she'd have us waiting, held/breath"
  - Metaphor alluding to "spinning" wheels and "sleeping heads of children" refers to the way fairytales are

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

Ballantyne, James. "Liz Lochhead and the Fairies: Context and Influence in Grimm Sisters and Dreaming Frankenstein." Scholar Commons, 13 June 2023, https://scholarcommons.sc.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=2326&context=ssl. Accessed 23 August 2025.
Donaldson, William (2022) "Liz Lochhead and the Fairies: Context and Influence in Grimm Sisters and Dreaming Frankenstein," Studies in Scottish Literature: Vol. 48: Iss. 2, 168–192.

DOI: 10.51221/suc.ssl.2023.48.2.13
https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/414779-2020-specimen-mark-scheme-1.pdf.
Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty
- Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder →

Help me understand

Test yourself

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Resources

Learning Hub

Scholarship

Join

Past Papers

Solution Banks

Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview

Brand ambassador

Profile

Subscription

Settings

Log out

Company

About us

Exam Specificity

Content Quality

Promotions

Jobs

Terms

Privacy

Cookie Policy

Help and Support

Subjects

Biology

Chemistry

Physics

Maths

Geography

English Literature

Psychology

All Subjects

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.

Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.